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Why We Tell the Story
Community & RCM Narratives

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21 October 2026

UK Research and Innovation

10.5281/zenodo.23340574

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Agenda

1. Introduction [2 min]
2. Exercise 1: Your Origin [10 min]
3. The role of narratives [10 min]
4. Exercise 2: RCM Origins [10 min]
5. Closing remarks [5 min]

Goal

Understand how we can use narratives to explain the RCM role to people who don't know about it

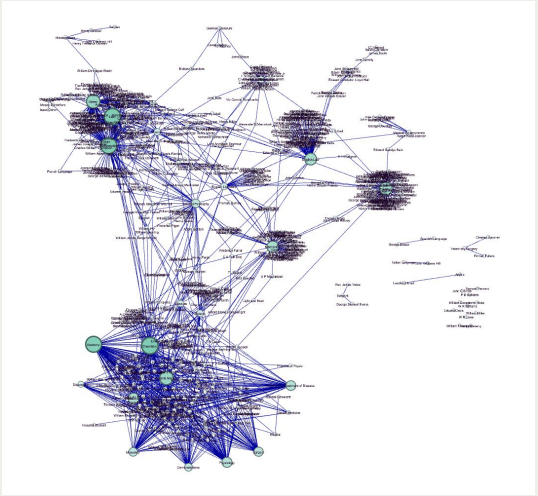
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Introduction



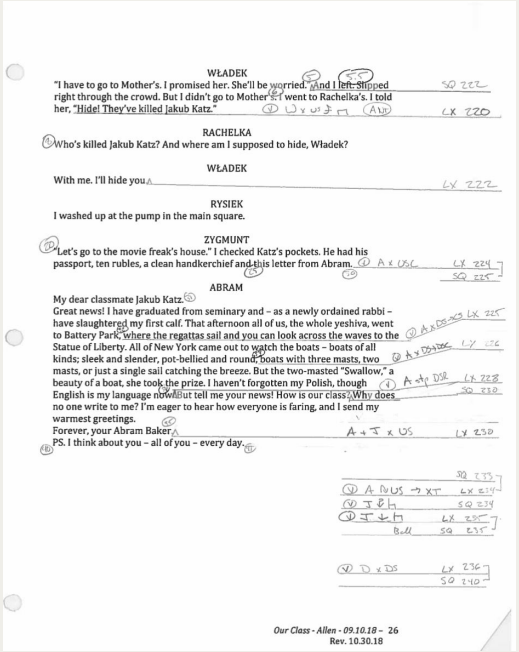
My origin story



Network analysis visualisation of students at the University of London, 1828

Community Management

Calling script from *Our Class* production in Washington, DC (2018)



WLADEK

"I have to go to Mother's. I promised her. She'll be worried. And I left. Slipped right through the crowd. But I didn't go to Mother's. I went to Rachelka's. I told her, "Hide! They've killed Jakub Katz."

RACHELKA

Who's killed Jakub Katz? And where am I supposed to hide, Władek?

WLADEK

With me. I'll hide you.

RYSIEK

I washed up at the pump in the main square.

ZYGMUNT

Let's go to the movie freak's house." I checked Katz's pockets. He had his passport, ten rubles, a clean handkerchief and this letter from Abram.

ABRAM

My dear classmate Jakub Katz,
Great news! I have graduated from seminary and – as a newly ordained rabbi – have slaughtered my first calf. That afternoon all of us, the whole yeshiva, went to Battery Park, where the regattas sail and you can look across the waves to the Statue of Liberty. All of New York came out to watch the boats – boats of all kinds; sleek and slender, pot-bellied and round, boats with three masts, two masts, or just a single sail catching the breeze. But the two-masted "Swallow," a beauty of a boat, she took the prize. I haven't forgotten my Polish, though English is my language now. But tell me your news! How is our class? Why does no one write to me? I'm eager to hear how everyone is faring, and I send my warmest greetings.
Forever, your Abram Baker
PS. I think about you – all of you – every day.

Our Class - Allen - 09.10.18 - 26
Rev. 10.30.18

Origin stories

1. They provide part of the foundation for a community to develop a shared identity. (Internal role)
2. They help make a community legible to people outside of that community. (External role)

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Exercise 1: Your personal origin story



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Exercise 1: Your personal origin story

10 minutes

1. Break into groups of four (4)
2. One (1) person will describe their RCM origin story [3-5 min]
   a. ‘How did you become/get interested in/find out about RCM?’
   b. Everyone else will listen & take notes in shared document
3. Reflect in your groups on how you received the story [5 min]
   a. What details stood out to you?
   b. Did you notice any specific inflection points?
   c. How did the notes differ between each notetaker?

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The Role of Narrative in Communities

Origin stories

1. Foundation for a community to develop a shared identity.
2. Make a community legible to people outside of that community.

‘Communities are to be distinguished [...] by the style in which they are imagined…’

- Benedict Anderson, *Imagined Communities*



The Turing Way Community. This illustration is created by Scriberia with The Turing Way community, used under a CC-BY 4.0 licence. DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.3332807

Origin stories

1. Foundation for a community to develop a shared identity.
2. Make a community legible to people outside of that community.

Drawing on a community of practice model → ‘Narration is the process by which members share information and build communal wisdom. Often, this process quite literally involves telling stories which hold lessons for how to approach particular problems.’

- Me (in a 2023 draft paper apparently)

Articulate the RCM role to people who don’t know it



The Turing Way Community. This illustration is created by Scriberia with The Turing Way community, used under a CC-BY 4.0 licence. DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.3332807

Example 1: Digital Humanities

Origin story: In the United States, digital humanities grew out of public humanities projects like *The Valley of the Shadow* (1991, UVA & IBM)

Shared identity: A field interested in ‘new media’, digitisation and US history.

External legibility: Case for the ‘relevance’ of the humanities and leader of the ‘interdisciplinary’ movement

Why?: You might be interested in DH if you like public engagement, teaching or media studies.

Example 2: Digital Humanities (again)

Origin story: Robert Busa, the *Index Thomisticus* (1949-89), and IBM – using computational methods to answer humanities questions.

Shared identity: Interested in innovation (new methods), traditional humanistic inquiry (research questions) and collaboration

External legibility: Provides concrete example, explains affordances of technology, extends the history of the discipline

Why?: You might be interested in DH if you like text technologies, big data and linguistics.

Example 3: Digital Humanities (again, again)

Origin story: Robert Busa, the *Index Thomisticus* (1949-89), and IBM – using underpaid/unpaid women to perform key but unacknowledged labour

Shared identity: Interested in social infrastructure beneath technologies, intersectionality and avoiding ‘great man’ theories

External legibility: Labour conditions are important for digital (research) technologies, discipline is interested in self-criticism

Why?: You might be interested in DH if you want to unearth the lived experience of people who make technology work.

Role of narrative

- Starting point & orients a community
- Articulates values
- Shapes identity, tradition & expectations
- Concrete example for outsiders



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Narrative of roles

- Stage managers
- Research software engineers
- Research community managers?

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Good narratives…

- Are concise, easy to remember, and should both answer & provoke questions
- Think about their audience (often the educated non-expert)
- Appropriately detailed (the ‘just right’ principle)
- Provide an entrance into the community (‘generous exclusion’)

Bad narratives…

- Are too nuanced, too vague, or assume prior knowledge
- Rely on negative stereotypes or ‘punch down’
- Don’t tell a story

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Exercise 2: The RCM origin story

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Exercise 2: The RCM origin story

10 minutes

1. Return to same breakout groups
2. Working together, start drafting an origin story for research community managers
3. As you are writing, think about:
    a. What does it mean for the community if we emphasise different origins/activities? What values become more evident?
    b. Who are the audiences for this story?

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Wrap up

Discussion - not about finding a single story, but identifying common themes or useful narratives that we can draw on when advocating

Outcome - generating a range of possible narratives to use when talking about the RCM movement and seeing where origin stories converge

Homework - do this exercise for the community you manage/work in

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